

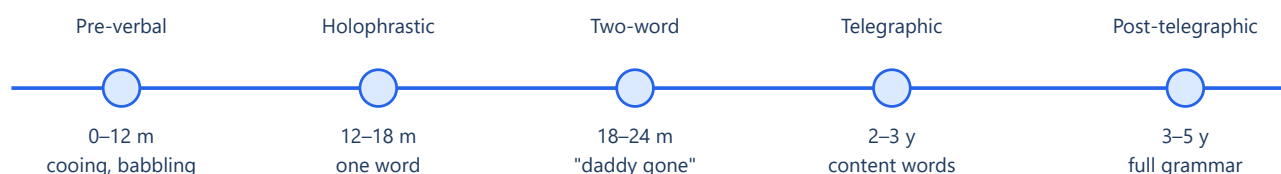
- RAG Learning

1.3 Children's Spoken Language Development

AQA A-Level English Language (7702) — Paper 1 Section B (3.1.3)

This section covers how children acquire their first language from birth to around age 11. You need to know the **stages** of phonological, lexical, grammatical and pragmatic development, the major **theorists** (Skinner, Chomsky, Piaget, Vygotsky, Bruner, Halliday), key **evidence** (Berko, Genie, Tomasello), and how to apply all of this to an unseen transcript.

Stages of Spoken Language Development (approximate ages)



1.3.1 Stages of Development

Pre-verbal (0–12 months)

- **Crying / reflexive vocalisation** (0–2 months).
- **Cooing** (2–5 months) — vowel-like sounds, especially /u/ and /i/.
- **Babbling** (6–12 months) — reduplicated syllables ("bababa"), then variegated ("bada").
- By 12 months, babbling narrows to phonemes of the ambient language.

Holophrastic / one-word (12–18 months)

Single words function as whole utterances. "Milk" might mean *I want milk, that is milk, where is the milk*. Context disambiguates. Typical early vocabulary (Katherine Nelson, 1973, from 18 children) falls into six categories: **general nominals** — class nouns such as *ball, cup, dog* — which are much the largest group at about 51%; **specific nominals**, names for one particular thing such as *Mummy* or a pet's name, ~14%; **action words** (go, eat) ~13%; **modifiers** (big, hot) ~9%; **personal-social** (hi, no) ~8%; and grammatical **function words** (what, for) ~4%. The headline finding is that nouns come first, and mostly *general* ones — don't reverse this and say specific nominals dominate.

Two-word stage (18–24 months)

Two content words in consistent semantic relations: *daddy gone* (agent + action), *more juice* (recurrence + object), *no bed* (negation + location). Word order is typically target-like — evidence for early syntactic knowledge.

Telegraphic stage (2–3 years)

Three+ content words, function words (articles, auxiliaries, inflections) still often omitted: *daddy gone shop, me want biscuit*. Named after telegrams which used only content words.

Post-telegraphic (3–5 years)

Function words appear; tense, aspect and agreement become regular; embedded clauses emerge; questions with proper subject–auxiliary inversion develop. By school age most core grammar is acquired.

1.3.2 Phonological Development

- **Cluster reduction** — "poon" for "spoon".
- **Substitution** — /w/ for /r/ ("wed" for "red"), /d/ for /ð/ ("dat" for "that").
- **Deletion** of unstressed syllables — "nana" for "banana".
- **Assimilation** — making nearby sounds more similar: "doggy" → "goggy".
- **Fis phenomenon** — child says "fis" for "fish" but rejects an adult saying "fis" — shows perception leads production.

1.3.3 Lexical and Semantic Development

- **Overextension** — a word used too broadly: "dog" for all four-legged animals.
- **Underextension** — a word used too narrowly: "dog" only for the family pet.
- **Mismatch errors** — completely unrelated reference.
- **Vocabulary spurt** — around 18 months, rapid increase in word learning.

1.3.4 Grammatical Development & Virtuous Errors

A **virtuous error** is an over-generalisation of a grammatical rule: "goed" for "went", "mouses" for "mice". Crucially the child has never heard these forms — they are produced by applying a rule. This is decisive evidence against pure imitation: children extract rules rather than memorising utterances.

The **Berko wug test** (1958) presents a child with a novel creature called a "wug"; asked to complete "Now there are two ___", children reliably say "wugs". This demonstrates *productive* knowledge of the plural morpheme /s/, not rote learning.

1.3.5 Pragmatic Development & Halliday's Functions

M.A.K. Halliday proposed seven **functions** that describe why children use language — functions emerge before complex grammar:

Function	Purpose	Example
Instrumental	Getting needs met	"want juice"
Regulatory	Controlling others' behaviour	"no bed"
Interactional	Maintaining social bonds	"hi mummy"
Personal	Expressing feelings / identity	"me happy"
Heuristic	Exploring / learning	"what's that?"

Imaginative	Play / fantasy	"I'm a dragon"
Representational	Conveying information	"doggy barking"

1.3.6 Theories of Language Acquisition

Behaviourism — Skinner

B.F. Skinner (1957) argued children learn language through **imitation**, **operant conditioning**, and **positive reinforcement**. When a child produces a target form, caregivers respond positively and strengthen the behaviour. Incorrect forms are not reinforced and fade.

Evaluation: imitation plays some role (especially in lexis and pronunciation), but behaviourism cannot explain virtuous errors (children produce forms they've never heard), rapid acquisition, or the fact that corrections are rarely systematic.

Nativism — Chomsky

Noam Chomsky argued humans are born with an innate **Language Acquisition Device (LAD)** and a **Universal Grammar (UG)**. Exposure to any language triggers this biologically-given capacity.

Evidence:

- **Poverty of the stimulus** — input is incomplete, yet children converge on full grammar.
- **Virtuous errors** — show rule-learning.
- **Critical period** (Lenneberg) — language is best acquired before puberty.
- **Universals** — all languages share deep structural features.

Evaluation: explains speed and creativity but downplays the role of input and interaction.

Cognitive — Piaget

Jean Piaget saw language as dependent on underlying cognitive development. A child cannot use a concept linguistically until they have grasped it cognitively (e.g. object permanence precedes consistent reference). Limitation: Vygotsky and later work show language can *drive* cognition, not just reflect it.

Social interactionism — Bruner, Vygotsky

- **Jerome Bruner:** the **Language Acquisition Support System (LASS)** — caregivers scaffold language through joint attention, recasting, expansion and routines (picture-book reading, peekaboo, feeding scripts).
- **Lev Vygotsky:** the **Zone of Proximal Development (ZPD)** — the space where a more competent partner can help the learner achieve what they cannot alone. Language is fundamentally social and acquired through social interaction.
- **Colwyn Trevarthen:** **proto-conversations** — pre-verbal infants and caregivers engage in turn-taking with gaze, gesture and vocalisations.
- **Michael Tomasello:** *usage-based* theory — grammar is learned from exposure to constructions; shared intentionality and joint attention are central.

1.3.7 Child-Directed Speech (CDS)

CDS (or "motherese", "parentese") is the register caregivers use with infants. Common features:

- Higher pitch, exaggerated intonation contours.
- Slower tempo and clearer articulation.
- Simplified, concrete vocabulary.
- Repetition — same questions, same frames.
- Recasting — repeating the child's utterance in full form: *Child: "ball gone". Adult: "Yes, the ball has gone."*
- Expansion — adding information: *Adult: "The ball has rolled under the chair."*
- Reference to the here-and-now — supporting word learning through joint attention.

Applied Example: A picture-book routine at 18 months exemplifies multiple theories at once: joint attention (Bruner), exaggerated prosody (CDS), labelling supporting Halliday's heuristic function, scaffolding within the ZPD (Vygotsky), and input that activates the innate capacity (Chomsky). Top-band exam answers weave several theorists together in a single paragraph.

1.3.8 Evidence — Case Studies and Experiments

Genie (Curtiss, 1977)

Genie was a girl isolated from language and human contact until age 13. After rescue, she acquired substantial lexis but never mastered complex grammar. This is often cited as support for the **critical period hypothesis**: first-language acquisition is severely impaired after puberty. Caveats: trauma and neglect are potential confounds; a single case cannot definitively prove the hypothesis.

The Wug Test (Berko, 1958)

Demonstrated productive knowledge of regular morphology in children as young as four. Evidence for rule-based (nativist) learning.

Bard and Sachs, Jim (hearing child of deaf parents)

A boy exposed to language primarily through television failed to acquire full grammar. Shows that input alone is not sufficient — *interactional* input is essential, supporting Bruner and Tomasello.

Tomasello's studies

Showed infants track speaker intention from around 12–14 months and use this to infer word meaning. Emphasises shared intentionality over purely innate mechanisms.

1.3.9 How to Analyse a Transcript at A-Level

When given a child-language transcript, apply a layered approach:

1. **Stage** — estimate the stage from utterance length, grammar, lexis.
2. **Phonology** — note any transcribed pronunciation features.
3. **Lexis & semantics** — are there overextensions, underextensions, vocabulary choices?
4. **Grammar & morphology** — word order, inflections, virtuous errors, subordination.
5. **Pragmatics (Halliday's functions)** — what is the child *doing*?
6. **Interaction** — how does the caregiver scaffold (recasting, expansion, questioning)?

7. **Theoretical lens** — apply at least two theorists explicitly, linking evidence in the transcript to their claims.

Exam Tip: Do NOT simply name-drop theorists ("this supports Chomsky"). Anchor each theoretical claim in specific features of the transcript. "The child says 'I goed' — a virtuous error showing rule over-generalisation. This supports Chomsky's nativist account: the child cannot have imitated a form they have never heard." That is what AO2 looks like.

Key Terms Checklist

Make sure you can define and give an example of each: **pre-verbal / holophrastic / two-word / telegraphic / post-telegraphic stages, babbling, cooing, overextension, underextension, virtuous error, wug test, CDS (motherese), recasting, expansion, LAD, LASS, ZPD, joint attention, critical period, Halliday's seven functions, fis phenomenon, Genie, Tomasello, proto-conversation.**